

where subscribers live and what their interests are so they can deliver personalized offers to customer's inboxes.

Whatever their flaws, coupons and online sites will most likely thrive and become even more personalized and accessible. That might be seen as beneficial for the frugal consumer, but the advantages of online coupons are actually greater for the companies themselves. For years, shoppers have been taking advantage of coupons, but now coupons could be taking advantage of the consumer. Some of the new coupons, downloaded from the Internet or sent to mobile phones, are loaded with information about the customer who uses it. The bar codes include information about the customer, their Internet address, and even their Facebook page information. In many cases, the coupons can be traced to the person who printed them.

In a 2010 investigative series, "What They Know," *The Wall Street Journal* looked at just how fundamental web technologies can now jeopardize user privacy, with websites installing new and intrusive consumer-tracking techniques. The Journal's study shows the extent to which web users are exchanging their personal data for access to information and services. They examined the fifty most popular websites in the US to measure the quantity and capabilities of the "cookies" and other trackers installed on a visitor's computer by each site. The fifty sites installed a total of 3,180 tracking files on a test computer used to conduct the study. Only one site, Wikipedia.org, had none installed. Two-thirds of the tracking tools came from 131 companies that are mostly in the business of following Internet users to create databases of consumer profiles that can be sold. The companies that placed the most tools were Google Inc.,